



little kid, watching since I was five or six years old. This is great for me and something I will enjoy with my people." The dramatic final overshadowed an even closer and higher-quality semifinal when Alcaraz overcame Sinner 2-6, 6-3, 3-6, 6-4, 6-3. It marked the youngest Grand Slam semifinal since Andy Murray defeated Nadal at the 2008 US Open.

The 22-year-old Sinner, the reigning Australian Open champion, was the Tour's biggest winner this year — 33-2 — and on June 10, took over the No. 1 ranking from Djokovic, who withdrew from Roland Garros due to a torn meniscus after beating Argentina's Francisco Cerundolo in a five-set quarterfinal.

During the 2020 pandemic, Ricardo Piatti, then Sinner's coach, used the break to educate him about the mentality of champions. He had Jannik watch two matches of the legendary Big Three — Djokovic, Nadal, and Federer — every day. Not their best matches, though. These were matches they didn't play well yet managed to win. The purpose was to

Idol inspiration: Echoing the philosophy of Nadal, Alcaraz viewed his gruelling 4-four, 9-minute victory in almost life-and-death terms. AFP

teach Sinner how to problem-solve during adversity.

Last year the wiry 6'3" Sinner added seven pounds of muscle to his legs, revamped his service motion, changed his stance from a platform to step-up, and under the tactical tutelage of Darren Cahill, added variety to his previously one-dimensional power game. Both players skipped the Rome Masters — Alcaraz had a forearm injury that required him to wear a long sleeve, and Sinner had a lingering hip injury.

Sinner's main advantage over the more athletic Alcaraz was on the backhand. Entering the semifinals, Sinner was plus 20 on winner to errors, while Alcaraz was minus 33.

After splitting the first two hard-hitting sets, both players suffered cramps in the third set: Alcaraz's right hand and Sinner's right forearm and left thigh. Alcaraz

learned from last year's semifinal loss to Djokovic when he was hobbled by full-body cramps that he had to stay calm and keep fighting. Alcaraz lost the third set 6-3 but converted his only break point with a backhand winner to take the fourth set, 6-4.

The broad-shouldered Spaniard got the only service break of the deciding set (6-3) in the second game thanks to a spectacular backhand passing shot on the dead run and a forehand winner.

As *Tennis Channel* analyst Martina Navratilova said, "Carlos played the big points better, was more aggressive and adventurous, had more gas left in his tank, and had more arrows in his quiver."

Echoing the philosophy of Nadal, Alcaraz viewed his gruelling 4-four, 9-minute victory in almost life-and-death terms. "You have to find the joy [while] suffering. That's the key — here at Roland Garros. Long rallies. Four-hour matches. Five sets. You have to fight. You have to suffer. But as I told my team many times, you have to enjoy suffering."